Episode 2

The Whispering Pagoda

វត្តឃ្មឹបខ្សៀវ

Game Design and Narrative Specification

Setting	Village pagoda and scripture library, Battambang Province
Night	Night 4 · last night of Pchum Ben · 11:45 PM – 4:00 AM
Playtime	1.5 – 2 hours
Seal	#2 · The Silver Betel Box
Version	3.0 · October 2026 · Draft for review

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01 Episode Overview

On the last night of Pchum Ben, when the dead walk among the living, Sora goes to the village pagoda for the second seal. Blind hungry ghosts hunt by sound among her ancestors' stupas. In the scripture library she lives the night of the pact through her great-grandfather's eyes, and must decide what really happened.

LOCATION
Village pagoda
Stupa garden, prayer hall, library

NIGHT
Night 4 of 7
Last night of Pchum Ben

PLAYTIME
1.5 – 2 hours
3 acts + flashback

CORE MECHANIC
Sound-based stealth
Noise, breath, shutter, distraction

THREATS
Pret · Neak Ta shadow
Blind hunters · library attack

SEAL
#2 Silver Betel Box
Returned to the ancestors at dawn

1.1 Episode goal

Open the way to the scripture library, recover the **Silver Betel Box**, and return it to the family stupa at the 4:00 AM bell to break the second seal.

1.2 Content at a glance

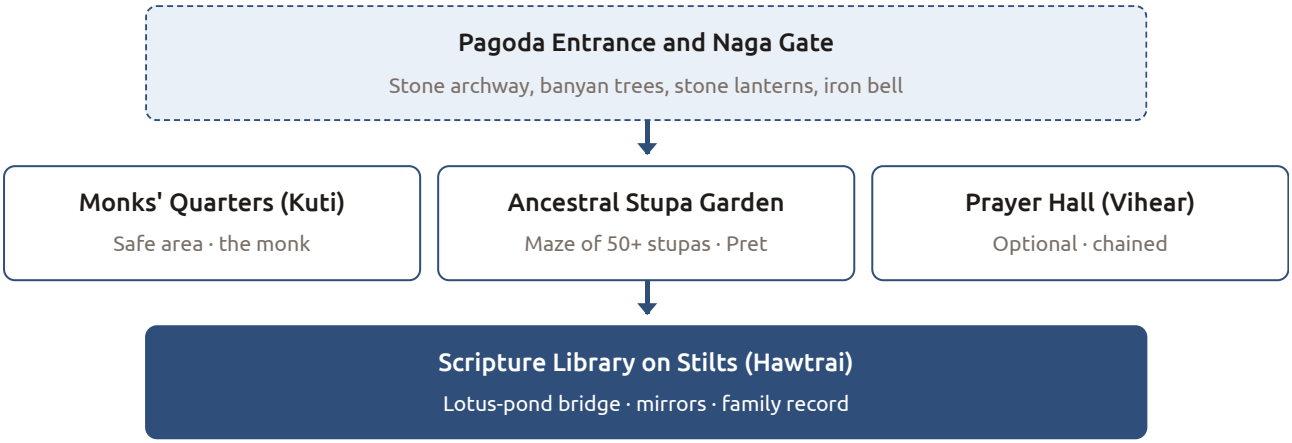
Puzzles (5)	Stupa offerings · temple bells (optional) · moonlight mirrors · the memory of 1910 · the dawn offering
Threat encounters (4)	Pret garden (escalating) · narrow passage with distraction · library attack · bridge escape
Optional area	The chained prayer hall (Vihear), opened by the temple bells
Formula break	A short playable flashback as Great-grandfather Chea in 1910
Key choice	Which words Chea really spoke at the shrine
Revelation	A 1920 photograph of Sok and a pregnant Kanha at a floating clinic

02 Characters

Character	Role	Description	Gameplay function
Sora សូរ៉ា	Protagonist	Shaken by her name on Sok's list, but determined. Uses her artist's eye to read inscriptions and map the stupas.	Player character.
Venerable Sophal ព្រះតេជគុណ សុផល 82	Head monk	Blind, gentle and cryptic. Knew Chea's family for decades. Keeps the betel box that Yay Mey entrusted to the pagoda in 1912.	Rules of the night; protective thread; stealth tutorial.
Chea ជា 1910, aged 70	Great-grandfather	A village elder watching his family starve and sicken. Desperate, proud and frightened.	Playable in the flashback.
The Pret ប្រេត	Enemies	Hungry ghosts 3–4 metres tall, with needle-thin necks, hollow glowing eyes and swollen bellies. Blind; they hunt by sound and the smell of offerings.	Escalating patrol enemies.
The Neak Ta shadow	Antagonist	Circles the pagoda's edge; attacks the library.	Act III pressure; escape.

Vuthy does not appear, but the monk mentions that "a young man in a town suit" came that evening asking about the betel box.

03 Locations and Layout



Area	Description and key props	Gameplay use
Entrance and Naga Gate	Crumbling stone archway with moss-covered Naga (នាគ); banyan leaves, stone lanterns, an iron bell on a beam. Low mist.	Arrival
Monks' Quarters កុដិ	Modest wooden huts with warm oil lamps.	Safe area; tutorial; supplies
Stupa Garden ចេតិយ	Over fifty carved ash stupas, 1–4 m tall, forming a maze of narrow dirt paths. Dry leaves, soft moss, stone. Trays of rice balls (បាយបិណ្ឌ), lotus bowls, inscriptions. Pale moonlight; black shadows.	Stealth maze; offerings
Prayer Hall វិហារ · optional	High-roofed brick hall, doors chained. A golden Buddha in shadow; murals of the Pchum Ben story; a bell rack outside.	Bell puzzle; two lore notes; spare oil
Scripture Library ហោរ្តៃ	A century-old carved teak building on stilts in a dark lotus pond, reached by a narrow plank bridge. Lacquer cabinets of palm-leaf manuscripts, brass braziers, bronze mirrors on swivelling stands.	Mirror puzzle; flashback; escape
Flashback: Forest Shrine, 1910	A starving village at night in the Kampong Cham forest; a path through the trees to a Neak Ta shrine of stacked stones under a great tree, wrapped in old cloth.	Playable memory

04 Story and Gameplay by Act

Act I · The Gates of Pchum Ben

Playtime 0:00 – 0:25 · 11:45 PM – 12:30 AM

Sora arrives by bicycle at **11:45 PM** on the last night of Pchum Ben (ភ្ជុំបិណ្ឌ). In the monks' quarters, Venerable Sophal tells her that the guardian returned Chea's silver betel box the morning after the pact, filled with earth: the sign that the offering was accepted. Yay Mey gave it to the pagoda for safekeeping in 1912. Sok tried to take it last year; the monk refused him. Tonight, he says, it belongs to the one who is named.

> *"Tonight, the hungry spirits walk among the ash stupas. They have no sight, but they hear every breath. Do not step into their path, and do not waste the rice offerings."*
>
> Venerable Sophal

He gives her a blessed white cotton thread. The player learns to crouch, read surfaces (dry leaves are loud, moss is quiet), hold breath and close the lamp's new **shutter**. Across the pond, a single Pret drifts past, too far to hear her: a lesson, not a threat.

Act II · The Hungry Garden

Playtime 0:25 – 1:05 · 12:30 – 2:15 AM

The gate to the lotus-pond bridge is sealed with a bronze lock of four symbols. Sora must find her four family stupas, belonging to Chea, his wife, Chhun and Kanha, and place the right offering at each. Every offering she places feeds the dead, and draws more of the hungry.

Element	Description
Stupa offerings	Match each ancestor to the right offering using inscriptions and the journal (section 6.1).
Distractions	Throw clay rice bowls to pull Pret away from narrow passages.
Temple bells new · optional	Strike the prayer hall's bells in the order of a verse painted on its wall to release the chains (section 6.2). Inside: two lore notes, including an old villager's account of what Chea asked for.

Act III · The Archive and the Memory of 1910

Playtime 1:05 – 1:45 · 2:15 – 3:45 AM

Sora crosses the bridge to the library. A beam of moonlight from the roof window must be guided across bronze mirrors to the silver lock of her family's cabinet (section 6.3). Inside lie the family record and the Silver Betel Box. As she opens the record, the room dissolves.

FLASHBACK · CHEA, 1910 FORMULA BREAK

The player *becomes Chea*: old hands, a guttering oil lamp, a village of empty houses and coughing children. He walks the forest path to the Neak Ta shrine, kneels and offers the silver betel box. A voice like grinding stone asks what he wants. The player chooses his words (section 7). The forest goes silent; the box grows heavy with earth.

The vision shatters. The Neak Ta shadow slams into the library walls; the building groans on its stilts.

ESCAPE

The roof splits; shelves collapse. Sora races across the breaking bridge as shadow tendrils reach from the black water.

Resolution · The Dawn Offering

3:45 – 4:00 AM

Sora kneels at Chea's stupa as the **4:00 AM bell** rings. She opens the betel box, pours its old earth at the stupa's foot, lights incense and speaks the names of her ancestors. The silver inlay on the lid comes loose in her hand; Seal #2 is broken. The Pret withdraw into the mist.

A photograph slips from the box's lining: *Tonle Sap clinic, 1920*. Uncle Sok in a medic's white coat stands on a floating wooden clinic; beside him, smiling and heavily pregnant, is **Sora's mother**. Blood seeps from its edges onto the map, darkening the second mark. Sora fills in the fourth circle. **Three nights remain.**

05 Threat Escalation

Stage	Threat	What changes
Act I	One distant Pret	Visible but out of hearing range; teaches how Pret move and listen.
Act II start	Two Pret	Slow, predictable patrols along the main paths.
After each offering	+1 Pret (up to five)	Each offering draws another, and patrols start crossing the side paths.
Act III	Neak Ta shadow	Attacks the library; tendrils from the pond during the escape.

06 Puzzles

6.1 The stupa offerings

Step	Action	Result
1	Compare the family emblem in the sketchbook with stupa carvings.	Four family stupas marked on the map.
2	Read inscriptions and journal notes for each ancestor's favourite offering.	Offering list in the sketchbook.
3	Collect rice balls, lotus buds and sanctified water.	Offerings in the satchel.
4	Place the correct offering at each stupa.	One lock symbol lights per offering; one more Pret joins the hunt.

6.2 The temple bells new · optional

Step	Action	Result
1	Read the verse painted on the prayer hall's outer wall; each line names a bell by its size or tone.	Order sketched in the sketchbook.
2	Strike the bells in that order. The sound carries, so Pret come to investigate.	The chains fall; the hall opens.

A high-risk, high-reward detour: the bells are loud, so the player must lure Pret away first or strike quickly and hide.

6.3 The moonlight mirrors

Step	Action	Result
1	Find the moonbeam from the roof window.	Puzzle start.
2	Rotate the mirrors to pass the beam across the room.	Beam reaches the cabinet.
3	Strike the silver lock.	Family record and Silver Betel Box.

6.4 The dawn offering

Step	Action	Result
1	Reach Chea's stupa before the 4:00 AM bell.	Checkpoint.
2	Pour out the box's earth, light incense, and speak the four ancestors' names in the right order (from the stupas).	The silver inlay comes loose; Seal #2 breaks.

07 Key Choice and Tracking

At the shrine, the guardian asks Chea what he wants. The family remembers a humble plea; the village remembers greed. The lore notes, especially the villager's account in the optional prayer hall and Chea's own confession in the family record, reveal the truth: he asked for both.

Chea's words (player choice)	Result
"Take what you will. Only save my children."	The family's version. The vision flickers. No change.
"Give us land and riches, and our line is yours."	The village's version. The vision flickers. No change.
"Save my children… and let us never be poor again."	The truth. The vision holds steady. **Respect +1.** The guardian values honesty.

Tracked in this episode	Source
Respect	No rice offerings wasted or knocked over (+1); honest memory (+1); ancestors' names in the right order at dawn (+1)
Knowledge (lore notes)	5 notes: two in the prayer hall, two in the library, one in the monks' quarters

08 Mechanics Reference

Mechanic	Rules	Feedback
Crouch	Lowers the camera, slows movement, roughly halves footstep noise (*target*).	Lower view; softer steps.
Surface noise	Dry leaves loud; stone medium; dirt and moss quiet.	Distinct footstep sounds.
Hold breath	Silences breathing for about 6 seconds (*target*); holding too long ends in a loud gasp.	Muffled audio; heartbeat.
Lamp shutter	Open / shuttered (still burning oil, no light) / out. Shuttering is instant; relighting costs a match.	Shutter visible on the lamp.
Distraction	Thrown rice bowls make noise where they land; limited supply.	Smash; Pret turn toward it.
Rice-offering taboo	Wasting or knocking over offerings counts as a broken taboo and draws nearby Pret.	Shriek; sketchbook note.
Flashback	Chea moves slowly (old, weak), with no shutter and a dim lamp. There is no fail state; this is a memory.	Aged hands; sepia-shifted image.

09 Items and Lore Notes

Item	Type	Found / use
Blessed white cotton thread	Key item	From the monk; used again in Episode 5
Clay rice bowls	Consumable	Stupa garden; distractions
Rice balls, lotus buds, sanctified water	Puzzle items	Trays, pond edge, monks' quarters
Family record	Story item	Library cabinet; triggers the flashback
Silver Betel Box	Seal #2	Library cabinet; its silver inlay is the Episode 5 remnant
1920 clinic photograph	Story item	Box lining; points to Episode 3
Lore notes ×5	Optional	Villager's account, Chea's confession, Pchum Ben mural notes, monk's letter, Sok's visit record

10 Audio and Visual Specification

Colour palette	Moonlight blue, mossy stone, deep navy, cold silver, warm lotus-candle gold. Flashback: warm sepia and sickly green.
Post-processing	Fog over water, shadows cast by the stupas, bloom on moonbeams, film grain.
Light sources	Shuttered lamp, moonlight, lotus oil cups, mirror reflections.
Ambience	Wind chimes, frogs in the pond, rustling leaves, distant bells and chanting.
Horror cues	Raspy Pret breathing and shrieks, creaking beams, splashes, whispered chanting, the guardian's grinding voice.
Interface	100% diegetic: shutter on the lamp; clues and night count in the sketchbook.

11 Glossary

Term	Khmer	Meaning	Note
Pchum Ben	ភ្ជុំបិណ្ឌ	Festival of the Dead	15 days; this is the final day
Bay Ben	បាយបិណ្ឌ	Rice-ball offerings	
Pret	ប្រេត	Hungry ghost	
Wat / Chedi / Vihear / Kuti / Hawtrai	វត្ត / ចេតិយ / វិហារ / កុដិ / ហោរ៉ាត្រៃ	Pagoda / stupa / prayer hall / monk's hut / scripture library	
Naga	នាគ	Serpent guardian	
Betel box	ប្រអប់ស្លា	Box for betel and areca	Replaces v1 "Hup Mak"; confirm

12 Revision Notes and Open Issues

Changes in v3.0

- Playtime reduced to 1.5–2 hours.
- New: the playable 1910 flashback and honest-memory choice; the temple bell puzzle and optional prayer hall; Pret escalation tied to offerings; the dawn offering that breaks the seal (fixing the v1 gap); the 1920 photograph of Sok and Kanha (replacing the 1925 photo).
- The pact now happens at a forest shrine in Kampong Cham, consistent with Episode 4.

Open issues

CONFIRM WITH THE CULTURAL ADVISOR

- Appropriate offerings at family stupas during Pchum Ben, and whether a lay person would pour earth or speak names there.
- Whether temple bells could plausibly be struck in sequence like this, or whether a drum or gong fits better.
- The correct Khmer form of address for a head monk.